

The idea of the nation as a political community

Susan Reynolds

The object of this chapter is to persuade those who need persuading, or are willing to be persuaded, that the concept of the nation that lies at the heart of all forms of nationalism was widespread long before the eighteenth century. This concept, as I understand, is the idea or assumption that nations are natural, given, objectively existing human communities, each of which is assumed, generally in a vague and unreasoned way, not only to have its own common culture, myths, history, and destiny, but also to be a political community with a right to what is now called self-determination. This definition is derived from that given by Anthony Smith in 1973, which lit up the subject for me in a flash and still seems to me a masterpiece of clarity.¹ He was setting out what he saw as the basic doctrine of nationalism, so that his definition was in effect a nationalist one. That seems to me inevitable, because nations are hard to identify and define except in terms of the beliefs about them held by those who think of them as real objective entities. I shall refer to this way of thinking about nations as 'nationalist', but that does not mean that I suggest that all who thought like this in the past had the same aims and policies as have those who are called nationalist today. Not that modern nationalism is at all uniform, but one thing all its varieties seem to have in common, and, as I argue, share with people in many pre-modern societies, is this idea of the objective reality of nations or peoples as communities with collective political rights as well as shared histories and cultures.

My argument is not that nationalism as it is generally understood was already rising in the Middle Ages. The whole idea of its 'rise' in any period may be misleading insofar as it subsumes the appearance of the idea of the nation into the appearance of the nationalist movements of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. The conflation of the two derives, I suggest, from an assumption that the only true nations that could arouse true nationalism are the nations of today, reflecting a fallacious teleology that assumes a single linear development towards the modern world. This assumption can

be maintained only by ignoring anything beyond textbook knowledge about pre-modern ideas on government and practices of government. That does not mean that I argue that nothing has changed. Although the idea of nations as political communities looks to me much older than most students of modern nationalism assume, its impact was changed when it came to be associated with other quite different ideas about the structure of society and government, as well as with different economies and different technologies. What I argue is that it was those external factors, not a change in the basic idea of nations or peoples as political communities, that produced modern nationalism.

Whether or not one chooses to call the concept of the nation that I am discussing a form of nationalism seems to me unimportant. If modernists want to reserve the word to the kind of nationalist movements that appeared in their period, that is fine. The earlier ideas about nations or peoples that I shall describe were not part of anything like a movement: though they were sometimes deliberately used to fortify existing polities, they seem to have been for the most part uncontroversial assumptions. If, on the other hand, modernists want to make the concession of calling these pre-modern ideas proto-nationalist, that is fine too, except that 'proto' always seems a little teleological. Words, however, seem to me to matter less in this context than the concepts or notions in the heads of those who use them, and the external phenomena to which they seem to be referring.²

I shall therefore not waste time arguing about words – nation, people, *gens*, *populus*, nationality.³ Fewer writers on nationalism now say such nonsensical things about the use or non-use of *natio* in the Middle Ages as used to be common, and anyway the particular words used in any particular language are irrelevant. What matters is the concepts or notions in the heads of those who use whatever words they use – which may not have been the same as the notions we have in our heads when we use those words. The notion or concept that I am concerned with is that of a natural community of descent and culture that is also a political community with political rights, even if it is not actually independent, that is, whether or not it is a state or (if the word is thought unsuitable for pre-modern polities) some other more or less independent polity.⁴ Since people do not always agree about which communities are nations or who belongs to which, it is difficult – unless one adopts a nationalist point of view – to see nations as objective phenomena. States or polities, on the other hand, however loose and variable the concept or notion of them may be, are easy to recognise as phenomena. They are facts: we live under them. The phenomenon of the practice of government in pre-modern societies suggests that the notion of

the nation as a natural political community reflected the phenomena of the collective nature of much government and its need of voluntary submission. The concept of the 'imagined community' that we call the nation and the phenomenon of the power structure were thus closely related, irrespective of whatever words people used for either in whatever language they spoke or wrote. The frequent use nowadays of the word 'nation' as a synonym for 'state' reflects some of the same assumptions.⁵ Analytically, however, the distinction between state and nation seems important.

In trying to trace the history of the concept or notion of the nation as a community of descent and culture that is also a political community we have to pay attention to the words used in our sources because they are all we have. But what we are really concerned with is the notions in the minds of people in the past, so far as we can deduce them from what they wrote, and the phenomena of government and politics to which they seem to have been referring. When I decided to use the word 'regnal' instead of 'national' in discussing medieval loyalties it was not, as Smith thought, because I thought medieval kingdoms were 'not nations in the modern sense',⁶ but because the word 'national' seems to make others focus on the modern 'nation-states', with their modern boundaries.⁷ Looking both at the phenomena of medieval power structures and at the ideas they seem to reflect suggests to me that medieval kingdoms were quite often perceived as something very like 'nations in the modern sense', as defined by Smith in 1973. They would not, I admit, qualify according to his later definitions that introduce 'common rights and duties for all members',⁸ but then, if women count as members, neither would the nineteenth-century collectivities that historians of nationalism count as nations.

In many societies and periods it has been taken for granted, however mistakenly, that areas under separate governments are also collective, corporate units of culture and descent: kingdoms in medieval Europe, for instance, were perceived by their own inhabitants not just as the territories that happened to belong to kings, but as territories that also belonged to the collective or corporate groups of their peoples.⁹ Medieval Europeans seem to have thought of kingdoms as the highest and most important units of government. Forget the old textbook idea of universal empire, which was used in polemics between pope and emperor but was never a serious threat to the supremacy of kings as the archetype of rulers and kingdoms as the archetype of political communities. Forget too that other textbook idea of medieval loyalties as exclusively local and fragmented by 'feudalism', which I have discussed elsewhere.¹⁰ Even when kingdoms were weak and divided they remained the model for the other, lesser

units that are often called feudal lordships. In the standard medieval view, government was the primary responsibility of kings and lords, but it was never their responsibility alone. All government was supposed to depend on custom. Custom implies a community that makes and follows it. Kingdoms were perceived as belonging not just to their kings but to the communities of their peoples (in Latin, *gentes*, *nationes*, or *populi*). All government rested, in both theory and practice, on the advice and consent of its greater subjects, who were supposed to represent the rest. Government came in layers (as it does today, most noticeably in federal states), but at every level units of government were perceived as communities bound by custom and mutual obligation, each of which depended on a lot of collective activity. At every level there needed to be what A. B. White called 'self-government at the king's command'.¹¹ He was talking about England, but he could have made much the same point about other polities. At every level people of higher status, the richer and more noble, were supposed to take the lead and bear responsibility, but they were also supposed to rule justly in the interests of the community of those under their authority and to consult with its senior members. Of course they did not always do either, and of course politics and law did not always fit the model of harmonious hierarchy and consensus. They never do conform to the ideals of their respective societies.

Kingdoms or other units of government in medieval Europe were also perceived as natural units, bound together not just by their present political unity but by their common descent. This was not argued about: it was just assumed, and myths were elaborated to express the assumption. In the seventh century a Frankish monk borrowed the Roman story of the descent of the Romans from the Trojans who left Troy after their defeat by Homer's Greeks. This was taken up by others so that the Franks, or the more literate among them, came to think of their people as descended from the Trojans. So did many other groups that formed political units. Descent from Trojans was claimed by the inhabitants of many cities and was attributed at one time or another to all the inhabitants of Britain. Others claimed to be descended from people in the Bible, and some mixed both Trojans and Bible characters into their collective genealogies. This may look silly to us, but it was perfectly rational at the time: both sets of stories had high authority, and without more archaeological and other information than people then had, it would have been difficult to show that either story was untrue or that the two were incompatible.¹²

Though all these ideas were too much taken for granted to be much, if at all, argued about, medieval governments sometimes used them to mobilise

support for their own purposes. One of the most eloquent pieces of propaganda I have ever read is the letter known as the Declaration of Arbroath, which seems to have been drafted by the servants of the king of Scots to be sent to the pope in 1320 in the name of the barons, freeholders and the whole community of the kingdom. According to the letter, the nation of the Scots (*natio Scottorum*) had come from Scythia and through the Pillars of Hercules to settle, after many troubles, in poor little remote Scotland. Despite many attacks from outside the Scots had lived in freedom under their own kings ever since until they were cruelly assailed by Edward I of England. We may doubt whether all of them were as determined to carry on their war of independence, irrespective of whether their king did so, as the splendid rhetoric of the letter maintains, but like all propaganda, it was presumably designed to appeal both to the barons who sealed it and to the pope. The ideas it articulates are therefore likely to have been around both in Scotland and at the papal court at Avignon.¹³

There are four points about all this that need emphasis.

First, most of the myths of collective origins that were told in medieval Europe were told about the inhabitants of kingdoms or other polities who, like the fourteenth-century Scots, were extremely unlikely to have had a long common descent. As political facts changed, stories were adapted to fit them. Because people in the Middle Ages assumed that the inhabitants of kingdoms formed peoples united by custom, law, descent, and sometimes, if language happened to fit, by language, old stories about kingdoms went on being told as the kingdoms or other units of government were altered. Provided a name went on, the story was assumed to fit the new or expanded polity. For instance, the story that the seventh-century Franks were descended from the Trojans was still told in the fourteenth century about the inhabitants of the kingdom of France, who were not all descended from those who had called themselves Franks in the seventh century and did not occupy the same territory. People just assumed that the inhabitants of the fourteenth-century kingdom were the same as the seventh-century Franks and used the old story to fortify the solidarity of the changed unit. The same goes for other groups. The perception of the inhabitants of kingdoms and other polities as political communities, and as enduring political communities, identified with the territories of those polities, looks to me very like the perception of the nation as a people identified with the territorial nation-state that historians of modern nationalism date from the French Revolution.¹⁴

The second point is that, though historians sometimes trace the origins of modern nationalism to the late Middle Ages and, in particular, to the

rise of what they call the 'national monarchies' of France and England, that does not do justice to the medieval evidence. Though these two so-called 'national monarchies' are often seen as the forerunners of their respective 'nation-states', neither kingdom was anything like coextensive with the modern state. It is, moreover, only by looking through the spectacles of modern nationalism that these two kingdoms appear to have had more national solidarity in the Middle Ages than had other polities that did not survive as independent states into modern times or bequeath their names to modern states. Saxony in the eighth century, Flanders and Normandy in the eleventh, and Venice throughout the Middle Ages may have been fortified as units of government by ideas of common culture and descent that were at that time just as widely and firmly held. Teleology is a bad guide to understanding the past. It is true that many polities that were envisaged as nations in the Middle Ages were smaller than most modern states, but if one thinks of nations as defined by being *perceived* as communities of descent, culture, and politics, it is not rational to disqualify medieval Venice or indeed ancient Athens because they were too small. Size seems to me relevant only if it is so great as to impede communication and solidarity.¹⁵

The third point about medieval ideas and assumptions about peoples that I want to note is that they combine cultural features – customs, language and religion – with genetic or biological features. Before the rise of modern genetics it was assumed that the two went together. Of course to some extent they do. People who form one society and are governed together tend to share at least some customs and they may become one linguistic group too in the long run (though, interestingly, not always). People living in one country and under one government also marry among themselves more than they marry outsiders and may in the long run therefore develop physical peculiarities that mark them off from people in other societies with whom they don't intermarry. In other words, cultural groups may correspond roughly to breeding populations. But the inhabitants of nation-states or those who wish to form a nation-state are not races insofar as races are understood to be groups with common and distinctive physical characteristics. Talking of 'races' at all may be misleading, since most geneticists now do not think that human beings can be divided into separate, nameable categories; but medieval people, in any case, seem to have noticed inherited physical differences much less than we do. They were, however, not in a position to distinguish physical inheritance from cultural transmission, for the distinction between them did not become obvious until the twentieth century, and even now is often not

recognised. Some scholars in the later nineteenth century began to worry about it, but it was only after Mendel's work was re-discovered in 1900 that the difference between racial or physical characteristics on the one hand and cultural characteristics on the other began to be worked out. Until then, the distinction between races and nations, racism and nationalism, could not be drawn.

The last point I have to make about the European Middle Ages is that the evidence does not seem to support the argument, most fully worked out by Anthony Smith, that ethnic solidarities came first and true political nationalism came later. According to this argument, groups before, say, the eighteenth century might have myths of common descent, a sense of a common culture, and a link with a particular territory, and their elites might have a measure of solidarity, but these characteristics had no real political content.¹⁶ But some of the communities that are allowed this kind of ethnic solidarity, as it is now called, had been independent polities at some point, or formed subordinate units which participated collectively in their own government within larger states. This seems to apply even in at least some parts of central and eastern Europe where significant cultural differences resulting from migrations or conquests survived into modern times, so that students of nationalism have tended to stress the detachment of ethnic loyalties from political structures.¹⁷ The medieval evidence suggests that ethnicity, the belief in common descent and customs and so on, was then quite often the result, rather than the cause, of political unity. That is not surprising. Ethnic groups do not have clear boundaries: it is hard to draw lines round cultures, and in medieval Europe custom and law did not fit political boundaries much better than cultures did. A shared history is generally not much more than a myth which can be easily adapted or re-written, while the distinction between a language and a dialect is as much a matter of politics as of the relative difficulty of communication. Although it is often difficult to tell which kind of solidarity, ethnic or political, came first, the evidence from medieval and early modern Europe suggests that, by and large, to borrow a phrase recently used by Colin Kidd, the 'ill-defined facts of "ethnicity" were shaped by the gravitational pull' of politics.¹⁸

To judge from my reading, such as it is, of non-European history and social anthropology, I suspect that, although one of the great myths of European history is that European political arrangements and social solidarities are unique, some of the same ideas about governments and communities as I have sketched were to be found in other, non-European societies, particularly where custom was the basis of law, long before

opposition to European imperialism provoked newer forms of nationalism.¹⁹ The new nations that have now emerged from colonial empires also illustrate the way that being governed together has stimulated political solidarities within colonial boundaries.²⁰ Often, of course, these new solidarities have to compete with those of pre-colonial units within or overlapping the colonial boundaries, but insofar as those were once more or less independent polities, they once again suggest that association under government prompts the kind of solidarities that find expression in claims both to common culture, history, and descent, and to collective self-determination.

By the later Middle Ages, the traditional idea of kingdoms and lesser units of government as communities of custom and descent was being undermined by two new ideas.²¹ Class distinctions became more fixed from the twelfth century and found expression in new myths by which separate origins were found for different classes. Rather later, a new political theory of absolutism began to emphasise rulers at the expense of their subjects, so that by the seventeenth century it was possible, at least for rulers and some intellectuals, to envisage a kingdom as merely the territory that its ruler ruled, with no identity or community apart from him. In practice governments remained rather more reliant on collective support and solidarity than was suggested by those who looked back on the *ancien régime* with horror. Historians sometimes stress the restricted nature of the 'political nation' or *Adelsnation*, but participation in politics in the supposed heyday of nationalism was not always much wider than it had been in the early modern period. However that may be, it was perhaps partly in reaction against theories of absolutism that another new set of ideas began to be worked out from the late seventeenth century on from a genuinely new set of premises: namely, ideas of popular government of a new and different kind, based not on old ideas of custom and law and community, but on the Rights of Man – individual natural rights independent of community or government. The stages by which these became combined with the old idea of existing, given political communities need further investigation by historians of eighteenth-century thought.²² In the meantime I submit tentatively two early examples of the way that the old ideas of nations came to be combined with the new individualist ideas.

First, Rousseau's ideas about the state of nature and the social contract, however idiosyncratic, clearly derive from the new paradigm. His ideas about nations clearly do not. He thought that peoples or nations had originated as communities of custom and way of life – what might be called merely ethnic communities, though they were now under

governments that he thought quite wrong. Nevertheless, the actual nations or peoples he mentioned by name or seems to have had in mind were all long-established units of government. That includes Poland, even if it was now in trouble, and Corsica, even if it had been passed around between different states like a parcel: it remained a single parcel and one whose inhabitants, or some of them, had ideas about their own collective rights.²³ Rousseau's nations, in other words, were what would have been assumed within an older kind of politics to be political communities. My other example is the Declaration of Independence. Its first two paragraphs offer a clear and concise combination of the old and new sets of ideas. Jefferson's belief in peoples with political rights looks as if it reflected the old assumptions and needed no justification or explanation, even though his 'people' had hitherto been connected by 'political bands' with another. What belonged unambiguously to the new ideas and needed formal statement, even though he claimed they were self-evidently true, were the equality and rights which men had had before the institution of government.

Popular government needs cohesive units in which to work. If one is going to make decisions by finding a majority of equal individuals one needs a collectivity in which votes can be counted and which is cohesive enough to hold together when opinions differ and after votes have been counted. Those who took up the new ideas of popular government found the cohesive collective units they needed in what they generally called nations.²⁴ Where a new nation had to be formed, such as that which comprised the thirteen American colonies or states, then the process, as they found, might be complicated and controversial;²⁵ but the important point I want to make is that, whether the political units were new or old, the basic ideas about nations or peoples were not new. They were old ideas even though, combined with new ideas about individualism and political equality, they now formed a significantly new form of nationalism that became much more explosive. Now the myths were not just universal assumptions: they were ideas that were consciously worked out and developed.

The way that they were worked out owed much to Germans who argued that people who spoke German, and were therefore a nation of common descent, ought to have some kind of political unity. The new philological nationalism they created was different from the old, not only because of the new emphasis on language, or because it came to be combined with new ideas of popular government which were of quite separate origin, but because it was articulated and rationalised in a way that the old

assumptions had not been. Instead of validating existing states it became a movement – a programme for creating new states. Both new and old states came to be called nation-states, and both new and old were different from the old states, but not because they were now thought of for the first time as political nations. The novelty was that they were based on a conscious ideology of nationalism which governments used as a means of internal control and of mobilisation for external conflicts. All the anomalies hidden in the old easy assumptions about nations were thus much more likely to be revealed and to fuel conflicts: disagreements about who formed a nation, about the boundaries of nations, all mattered much more now that nations came to be thought of as composed of equal individuals with equal rights to share in their governments.

The changes in the nature and conduct of politics during the past two hundred years were thus, I suggest, not the result of new ideas about nations as such but of other, quite separate political ideas about the structure of society and government within nations or states and – obviously – of new technologies of agriculture, industry and communications. All these brought changes in structures and methods of government, new methods of communication and control, the provision of mass education, the development of economic policies, and so on. These, however, were changes in states rather than in ideas about nations, even if nationalist thought and expression confuse the two and governments use the language of nationalism to muster mass support. Modern technology needs big states, and big states need more glue to hold them together. Ideas about the reality and rights of nations could provide the glue, just as they had done through simpler forms of communication with the smaller populations of the past. In earlier times most people may not have felt very involved most of the time, but nor do they now. In peaceful times loyalties to smaller groups take precedence and need not conflict with loyalties to the state or nation. The difference is that the articulation and fostering of nationalist ideas, combined with ideas of democracy, mean that, when smaller groups within states feel discontented, the same ideas also offer a solvent to dissolve the old glue.

In conclusion: of course there have been great changes. But one cannot argue that the idea of the nation as a political community as well as a unit of ethnic solidarity was new at any point in time without looking at the evidence of ideas before that point. All I argue is that the great changes sometimes lumped together as 'the rise of nationalism' did not include the idea of the nation as a natural human community – a 'self' – with its own common culture, myths, history and destiny, which by its very existence

has the right to self-determination. Looking more closely at earlier ideas about politics and the earlier practice of government would help to distinguish what was really new about modern nationalism and what came from other strands of thought. It might also help to achieve what John Breuilly has called 'a more explicit and selective view of the modernity/nationalism relationship'.²⁶

NOTES

- 1 Anthony D. Smith, 'Nationalism' (= *Current Sociology* 21/3, 1973), pp. 9–10.
- 2 What I call words, concepts, and phenomena are discussed in Charles K. Ogden and I. A. Richards, *The Meaning of Meaning* (London: Kegan Paul, 1923), pp. 13–15; further discussions in e.g. John Lyons, *Semantics* (Cambridge University Press, 1977), vol. 1, pp. 95–119, 175; Raymond Tallis, *Not Saussure: A Critique of Post-Saussurean Literary Theory* (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1988), pp. 114–16. As applied to medieval history: Ruth Schmidt-Wiegand, 'Historische Onomasiologie und Mittelalterforschung', *Frühmittelalterliche Studien* 9 (1982), 49–78; Susan Reynolds, *Fiefs and Vassals: the Medieval Evidence Reinterpreted* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1994), pp. 12–14.
- 3 Hugh Seton-Watson, *Nations and States: An Enquiry into the Origins of Nations and the Politics of Nationalism* (London: Methuen, 1982), p. 147, is useful on *Nationalität*.
- 4 On the use of 'state' in medieval history see S. Reynolds, 'The historiography of the medieval state', in Michael Bentley (ed.), *Companion to Historiography* (London: Routledge, 1997), pp. 117–38.
- 5 This seems to go back at least to Louis XIV: Hubert Méthivier, *Le siècle de Louis XIV* (Paris: PUF, 1988), p. 3.
- 6 Anthony D. Smith, *Myths and Memories of the Nation* (Oxford University Press, 1999), p. 31, n. 25.
- 7 S. Reynolds, *Kingdoms and Communities in Western Europe, 900–1300* (2nd edn, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1997) pp. 253–4.
- 8 E.g. Anthony D. Smith, *Nationalism: Theory, Ideology, History* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2001), p. 13.
- 9 The following paragraphs are based on Reynolds, *Kingdoms and Communities*, pp. xlv–lxii, 250–61, where fuller references are given.
- 10 Reynolds, *Fiefs and Vassals*.
- 11 Albert B. White, *Self Government at the King's Command: A Study in the Beginnings of English Democracy* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1933).
- 12 S. Reynolds, 'Medieval *origines gentium* and the community of the realm', *History* 68 (1983), 375–90, repr. in Reynolds, *Ideas and Solidarities of the Medieval Laity* (Aldershot: Variorum, 1995).
- 13 Archibald A. M. Duncan, *The Nation of Scots and the Declaration of Arbroath* (London: Historical Association, gen. ser. 75, 1970).

- 14 Stuart Woolf (ed.), *Nationalism in Europe, 1815 to the Present: A Reader* (London: Routledge, 1996), p. 2. Cf. F. Graus, 'Die Entstehung der mittelalterlichen Staat', *Historica* 10 (1965), 5–65.
- 15 Cf. Anthony D. Smith, *Theories of Nationalism* (2nd edn, London: Duckworth, 1983), p. 188.
- 16 Anthony D. Smith, *The Ethnic Origins of Nations* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1986), pp. 23–30; with slightly varying definitions in *Myths and Memories*, p. 127; *The Nation in History* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2000), p. 65; *Nationalism: Theory, Ideology, History*, pp. 12–13.
- 17 František Graus, *Die Nationenbildung der Westslawen im Mittelalter* (Sigmaringen: Thorbecke, 1980); B. Zientara, 'Nationale Strukturen des Mittelalters', *Saeculum* 32 (1981), 301–16; L. E. Scales, 'At the margin of community: Germans in pre-Hussite Bohemia', *Transactions of the Royal Historical Society*, 6th ser., 9 (1999), 327–52.
- 18 Colin Kidd, *British Identities before Nationalism* (Cambridge University Press, 1999), p. 287. Cf. Max Weber, *Economy and Society*, ed. and trans. G. Roth and C. Wittich (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1978), p. 389 (*Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft* [5th edn, Tübingen: Mohr, 1976], p. 237); Margaret Canovan, *Nationhood and Political Theory* (Cheltenham: Edward Elgar, 1996), p. 53; Roger Just, 'Who are "we"?', *Times Literary Supplement*, 8 May 1998, 11.
- 19 On stories of collective origin and history as reflecting current political situations see R. Finnegan, 'A note on oral tradition and historical evidence', *History and Theory* 9 (1970), 195–201; Jan Vansina, *Oral Tradition as History* (London: James Currey, 1985), pp. 19–24, 103–7; David P. Henige, *The Chronology of Oral Tradition* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1972), pp. 47–8, 54–5, 105–18, 163–5. On the identity of people and territory see e.g. Raymond Firth, *Primitive Polynesian Economy* (2nd edn, London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1965), p. 39; and of people, territory and kingdom see Max Gluckman, 'The Lozi of Barotseland', in Elizabeth Colson and M. Gluckman (eds.), *Seven Tribes of British Central Africa* (London: Oxford University Press, 1951), pp. 1–93, at pp. 19–21.
- 20 E.g. A. Seal, 'Imperialism and nationalism in India', in John Gallagher *et al.* (eds.), *Locality, Province and Nation: Essays in Indian Politics 1870 to 1940* (Cambridge University Press, 1973), pp. 1–27; John Iliffe, *A Modern History of Tanganyika* (Cambridge University Press, 1979), pp. 8–10, 318–41, 485–90.
- 21 S. Reynolds, 'Our forefathers? Tribes, peoples and nations in the age of migrations', in Alexander C. Murray (ed.), *After Rome's Fall: Narrators and Sources of Early Medieval History. Essays Presented to Walter Goffart* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1998), pp. 17–36, with references.
- 22 Hans Kohn, *The Idea of Nationalism* (New York: Macmillan, 1945), pp. 227–325. Despite his teleological concentration on the past of modern 'nation-states' and the unreality of his picture of the Middle Ages, which for long led me to discount him, Kohn seems to have treated this subject more seriously than later writers on nationalism.
- 23 *Œuvres complètes*, vol. III, ed. Bernard Gagnebin *et al.* (Paris: Gallimard, 1964), pp. 169 (*Discours sur l'origine de l'inégalité*, pt 2), 381–3, 386, 391 (*Contrat social*,

- 2.7, 8, 10); F. M. Barnard, 'National culture and political legitimacy: Herder and Rousseau', *Journal of the History of Ideas* 44 (1983), 231–53.
- 24 Canovan, *Nationalism*, pp. 14–22, 101–2.
- 25 Cf. Oliver Zimmer, *A Contested Nation: History, Memory and Nationalism in Switzerland, 1761–1891* (Cambridge: Past & Present Publications, 2003).
- 26 J. Breuilly, 'Reflections on nationalism', *Philosophy of the Social Sciences* 15 (1985), 65–73, repr. in Woolf (ed.), *Nationalism*, pp. 137–54.

CHAPTER 3

*Changes in the political uses of the nation:
continuity or discontinuity?*

John Breuilly

INTRODUCTORY REMARKS*

In this essay I consider the claims that nations existed in pre-modern history and that political arguments appealing to such communities were significant. I argue that the limited evidence available from the pre-modern period suggests two principal ways in which the term 'nation' was used: ethnographically, to describe 'barbaric' societies, and as political self-description, usually of a territorial kingdom. The nation was subordinated to values associated with civilisation and monarchy. Strong claims for the nation as a 'whole society' with a widespread and continuous sense of national identity elide this ethnographic/political distinction and ignore the subordinate value nation plays in both kinds of discourse. Furthermore, those arguing for a significant pre-modern sense of nationality conflate fragmented pieces of evidence in which 'nation' and cognate terms are used, investing these with a coherence, continuity and political importance they did not possess.

I argue that national identity, understood as the processes of maintaining, reinterpreting and transmitting the values associated with the nation, has weak force in the pre-modern period because it operates discontinuously and does not fuse cultural identity with political interest, and its impact – often highly opportunistic and contingent – is confined to court, noble and Church elites. Finally, in this critical part of the essay, I suggest that nation and national identity (though not nationalism) become significant in specific parts of Europe during the confessional disputes of the early modern period but that this can be accommodated within a modernist framework.

In the second part of the essay I briefly outline the transformations of modernity which radically alter the concept of the nation, strengthen

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